

1

IN SEARCH OF ADVENTURE

! What drives people
to seek out adventure?



Introduction

To go on an adventure is to journey into the unknown. From quests to slay dragons to exploring the edge of space, adventures can thrill readers as well as the people who experience them. But what drives people to seek out adventure?

In this unit, you will explore extracts from stories, poems and non-fiction writing about adventure, meeting real-life explorers as well as some famous fictional adventurers too.

ignite *INTERVIEW*

Mick Conefrey, Adventure writer and documentary maker



Adventure is exciting because we like watching and reading about things that we would like to do. I am interested in reading stories about people climbing mountains or going to extreme places, because I would like to

be there. They are doing the things that I would like to do. But also there is a kind of sense that sometimes they are taking risks that I would like somebody else to take. If you look at the true stories of what has happened to people in the history of exploration, they are as extreme and as strange and as bizarre as anything you could make up.

Activities

1

What is the most adventurous thing you have ever done? This could be taking part in an adventurous sport or activity, visiting a faraway place or any other daring experience.

2

Discuss how you felt before, during and after the experience. Why do you think people seek out adventure?



1 The Hero's Journey

Objective

Explore the typical structure of adventure stories and relate this to your own reading.

Whether they are found in books or films, adventure stories often follow a similar structure, which is sometimes known as the hero's journey.



The hero's journey

The call to adventure

The hero or heroine receives a challenge that will take them away from their ordinary life, for example, a quest to follow or a dangerous mission to complete.

Into the unknown

The hero or heroine sets out on their adventure, entering a new world filled with dangers.

Trials and tests

On the path to their final goal, the hero or heroine encounters difficult obstacles that they have to overcome.

The final challenge

The hero or heroine faces their greatest challenge and must endure an ordeal to achieve the aim of their adventure.

Reward and return

The hero or heroine receives some form of reward and returns a changed person.

Activities

1

Discuss whether the adventure stories you have read or watched follow this structure. Why do you think this might be?

2

Create your own flow diagram, adding examples for each stage from books and films you have read or seen.

Now read the extract below where the writer, Christopher Booker, describes the plot of the earliest ever adventure story, the *Epic of Gilgamesh*, an ancient poem written over 5000 years ago.

Extract from *The Seven Basic Plots: Why We Tell Stories* by Christopher Booker

The first part of the **Sumerian** *Epic of Gilgamesh*, as we now know it, tells of how the kingdom of Uruk has fallen under the terrible shadow of a great and mysterious evil. The source of the threat is traced to a monstrous figure, Humbaba, who lives half across the world, at the heart of a remote forest. The hero, Gilgamesh, goes to the armourers who equip him with special weapons, a great bow and a mighty axe. He sets out on a long, hazardous journey to Humbaba's distant lair, where he finally comes face to face with the monster. They enjoy a series of **taunting exchanges**, then embark on a **titanic** struggle. Against such supernatural powers, it seems Gilgamesh cannot possibly win. But finally, by a superhuman feat, he manages to kill his monstrous opponent. The shadowy threat has been lifted. Gilgamesh has saved his kingdom and can return home triumphant...

3

Find any similarities between the plot of the *Epic of Gilgamesh* and adventure stories you have watched or read, e.g. James Bond, *The Lord of the Rings*, etc.

4

Write two paragraphs comparing the structure of two adventure stories you have read or watched. Use conjunctions to help you draw out interesting comparisons and contrasts between the stories.

SPAG

Conjunctions link different parts of a sentence. There are two main types of conjunction:

- A coordinating conjunction links two independent clauses in a sentence, e.g. *The Epic of Gilgamesh was written over 5000 years ago but Dr No is a 20th-century James Bond story.*
- A subordinate conjunction introduces a subordinate clause in a sentence, e.g. *While James Bond might be more famous, Gilgamesh is the original hero.*

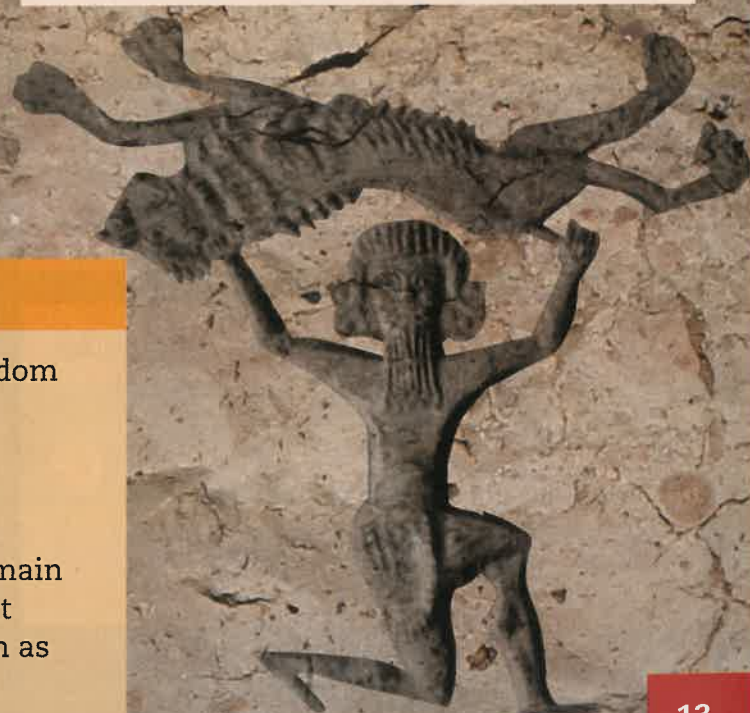
Glossary

Sumerian belonging to Sumer, an ancient kingdom located in modern-day Iraq

taunting exchanges insults and gibes

titanic colossal

subordinate clause a clause that supports the main clause in giving further explanation or detail, but cannot stand alone. It may start with words such as 'which', 'who', 'that' or 'when'.



2 The Call to Adventure

Objective

Investigate how a writer builds up expectations of an adventure story through character and setting.

At the beginning of an adventure story, something must happen that pulls the hero or heroine out of their everyday life and plunges them into an adventure. In the extract from the opening chapter of J. R. R. Tolkien's novel *The Hobbit* on page 15, Bilbo Baggins is standing outside his home when he sees a stranger approaching. Read the extract and then complete the activities.

Activities

1 Tolkien uses description and **dialogue** to introduce Gandalf to the reader. Discuss what you learn about the character from:

- the way Tolkien describes his appearance
- the way he speaks and what he says.

2 What impression do you get of Bilbo Baggins from this extract? Think about:

- what he says
- how he acts
- what he thinks.

3

Bilbo describes adventures as 'Nasty disturbing uncomfortable things!' that 'Make you late for dinner!' Discuss why you think Tolkien has chosen to make Bilbo the hero of this story.



4

What do you notice about the punctuation in this extract? Pick out some examples and comment on the effect that they have.

SPAG

Extract from *The Hobbit* by J. R. R. Tolkien

All that the unsuspecting Bilbo saw that morning was an old man with a **staff**. He had a tall pointed blue hat, a long grey cloak, a silver scarf over which his long white beard hung down below his waist, and immense black boots.

"Good morning!" said Bilbo, and he meant it. The sun was shining, and the grass was very green. But Gandalf looked at him from under long bushy eyebrows that stuck out further than the brim of his shady hat.

"What do you mean?" he said. "Do you wish me a good morning, or mean that it is a good morning whether I want it or not; or that you feel good this morning; or that it is a morning to be good on?"

"All of them at once," said Bilbo. "And a very fine morning for a pipe of tobacco out of doors, into the bargain. If you have a pipe about you, sit down and have a fill of mine! There's no hurry, we have all the day before us!" Then Bilbo sat down

on a seat by his door, crossed his legs, and blew out a beautiful grey ring of smoke that sailed up into the air without breaking and floated away over The Hill.

"Very pretty!" said Gandalf. "But I have no time to blow smoke-rings this morning. I am looking for someone to share in an adventure that I am arranging, and it's very difficult to find anyone."

"I should think so – in these parts! We are plain quiet folk and have no use for adventures. Nasty disturbing uncomfortable things! Make you late for dinner! I can't think what anybody sees in them," said our Mr Baggins, and stuck one thumb behind his braces, and blew out another even bigger smoke-ring. Then he took out his morning letters, and began to read, pretending to take no more notice of the old man. He had decided that he was not quite his sort, and wanted him to go away.

Glossary

setting the place and time where the novel occurs

dialogue conversation between two or more characters

staff a long walking stick

Progress Check

Produce a list of tips about how to use dialogue, action, description and punctuation to create an effective opening for an adventure story.

Extra Time

Read more of *The Hobbit* or other adventure stories by J. R. R. Tolkien.

3 Comic-book Heroes

Objective

Explore how dialogue, action and images are used to develop characterization in a graphic novel text.

Adventure stories are often found in comic books and graphic novels. Here, writers and illustrators use pictures as well as words to tell the story. In the extract from Jeff Smith's graphic novel *Bone* on page 17, Fone Bone and his friend Thorn are lost in the forest and surrounded by menacing rat creatures.

Activities

- 1 Who do you think the hero of this story is? Give reasons for your choice based on the extract.

Support

Look closely at how Fone Bone and Thorn are depicted, e.g. their actions, facial expressions and dialogue. Think about what these suggest about each character.

2

Drawing on your knowledge of adventure stories, discuss what you think will happen next in the story. Think about:

- what Fone Bone and Thorn might do
- how the rat creatures might react
- any other characters who might appear.

3

Create a script for the next page of the graphic novel. Use description and dialogue to show how the action develops.

Description: Thorn clasps Fone Bone protectively with one arm, while she points aggressively towards the rat creatures with her other free hand. The expression on her face is angry and defiant, while Fone Bone looks scared.

Dialogue: STAY BACK!

Sound effects: SSSSS---



Stretch

Think about the ways you can change the characterization of Fone Bone. Experiment with different captions and dialogue to make him either a brave or reluctant adventurer.



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'A good adventure has to have an element of risk, danger or jeopardy. Without risk there is no drama.'

Mick Conefrey

4 Polar Explorers

Objective

Understand how Elizabeth Bradfield conveys the dangers of exploration in her poem 'In the Polar Regions'.

What dangers lay in wait for the very first explorers who sought to conquer the harsh environment of Antarctica? Read Elizabeth Bradfield's poem 'In the Polar Regions' on page 19 and then complete the activities.

Activities

- 1 What do you think this poem is about? Share your ideas about the poem. Pick out details that you don't understand on first reading and discuss what these might mean.

Support

Some words and lines in poetry have more than one meaning. For instance, what different possible meanings might there be for the following lines?

'It takes a particular man for this, you know, able to be short-sighted for months on end.'

2

This poem is about the very first Antarctic explorers. What picture does Elizabeth Bradfield create of the difficulties and dangers of polar exploration at this time? Think about:

- who the narrator of the poem is and how Bradfield creates their voice
- what she suggests about the dangers and discomforts faced by polar explorers
- her use of imagery, including **metaphor** and **extended metaphor**.

3

Create a dramatic reading of the poem to teach other Year 7 students about the extreme experiences of some adventurers. Think about how you can use **intonation** and **tone** to communicate the emotions you want to evoke.

Stretch

Think about how you could use dramatic techniques such as tableaux (freeze frame) to accompany your reading of the poem.

Progress Check

Perform your dramatic reading in front of the class. Ask them to give you a rating, on a scale of 1 to 5, with 5 being the highest, on how effectively you used intonation and tone to evoke the emotions of the poem.

'In the Polar Regions' by Elizabeth Bradfield

Long from home. Glaciers capping the hills
like false teeth. It's not just the odd meat
we're carving, clawed flippers and flightless
wings, or the long-churned distance to any news of home,
any first-born or failing parent. There
are other signs this place is foreign. The ship
converses with ice packed around it, groans
and squeaks, an occasional outraged crack.

It takes a particular man for this, you know,
able to be short-sighted for months on end.
The air is constantly **aluminum** with snow,
and my mouth, too, tastes of metal. Salt
of iron seeping from my weakened gums.
Each morning, I pack drift around my tongue
to freeze the soft flesh holding my teeth.

It all goes to slush—ground underneath
our tents, my mouth, the knack for conversation.
Walking west, five of us have fallen
to dangle alongside cliffs of ice, the thin crust
breaking into chasm easily, as if such sudden transformations
were to be expected and we're the fools to be surprised.
Only a thin rope holds us to the surface. Hanging,
there's nothing to do but stare at the blue contours of freeze
and tongue our loosening teeth, test the stringy roots
that hold them, wait for a tug from the ones left above.

Glossary

metaphor describing something as something else, not meant to be taken literally, e.g. *You are a star.*

extended metaphor continuing the use of the metaphor throughout the whole text or a number of lines

intonation the rise and fall of a person's voice when they speak

tone the way words are spoken, e.g. a serious tone, a light-hearted tone, etc.

aluminum American spelling of aluminium



5 Unexpected Encounters

Objective

Examine how features of writing can be used to create suspense and tension in an adventure story.

One of the first novels written in English was *Robinson Crusoe* by Daniel Defoe. This adventure story tells the tale of a sailor, Robinson Crusoe, who is shipwrecked and cast away on a deserted island. In the extract on page 21, Crusoe is walking along the beach when he encounters an unexpected sight.

Activities

1 What does Crusoe see and why does this surprise him? Discuss how you think you would react in his situation.

2 How does Defoe show Crusoe's changing reactions? Pick out details from the extract and explain what they show about Crusoe's emotions.

3 How does the way the sentences are constructed help you to build up a picture of Crusoe's thoughts and actions? Explore how:

- commas are used to separate subordinate clauses
- conjunctions and semi-colons are used to link ideas
- the punctuation reflects Crusoe's thoughts and actions.

SPAG

Extract from *Robinson Crusoe* by Daniel Defoe

It happened one day, about noon, going towards my boat, I was exceedingly surprised with the print of a man's naked foot on the shore, which was very plain to be seen on the sand. I stood like one thunderstruck, or as if I had seen an **apparition**. I listened, I looked round me, I could hear nothing, nor see anything; I went up to a rising ground to look farther; I went up the shore and down the shore, but it was all one; I could see no other impression but that one. I went to it again to see if there were any more, and to observe if it might not be my fancy; but there was no room for that, for there was exactly the print of a foot – toes, heel, and every part of a foot. How it came **thither** I knew not, nor could in the least imagine; but after innumerable fluttering thoughts, like a man perfectly confused and out of myself, I came home to my **fortification**, not feeling, as we say, the ground I went on, but terrified to the last degree, looking behind me at every two or three steps, mistaking every bush and tree, and fancying every stump at a distance to be a man. Nor is it possible to describe how many various shapes my affrighted imagination represented things to me in, how many wild ideas were found every moment in my fancy, and what strange, unaccountable **whimsies** came into my thoughts by the way.

Glossary

apparition ghost

thither to that place

fortification fort

whimsies freakish ideas

Now read the extract from *Nation* by Terry Pratchett on pages 22–23. This tells the story of another castaway who is shipwrecked on a desert island, but this extract is told from the perspective of an islander, a boy called Mau.

4

Compare and contrast the ways the two extracts create a sense of tension. Look at:

- the events of the extracts
- the thoughts and actions of the characters
- the way punctuation and paragraphs are used.

SPAG

5

Continue the extract from *Robinson Crusoe*. Think about:

- what might happen next in the story, e.g. Crusoe meeting the person who has left the footprint
- the different sentence structures you can use to create tension and suspense
- how you can use paragraphs to show the sequence of events and add impact.

Stretch

For Activity 5, try writing in the style of Terry Pratchett's *Nation*.

Extra Time

Find out more about *Robinson Crusoe* and the real-life events that inspired the story.

More to
explore

Extract from *Nation* by Terry Pratchett

Mau peered round the **buttress** of a giant fig tree.

There was a lot to see.

Something had been wrecked, but it was not alive. It was some kind of giant canoe, stuck between the trunks of two trees and covered with debris that looked as though it would be worth investigating, but not now. A big hole in the side leaked stones. But all this was background. Much closer to Mau, and staring at him in horror, was a girl – probably. But she could be a ghost; she was very pale.

And a **trouser**man, too. The trousers were white and frilly, like the feathery legs of a grandfather bird, but she also had some kind of skirt tucked up around her waist. And her hair glowed in the sunlight. She had been crying.

She had also been trying to dig into the forest floor with some odd kind of flat-headed spear, which had the glint of metal about it. That was stupid; it was all roots and rocks, and there was a very small heap of rocks next to her. There was something else, too, large and wrapped up. Perhaps I did walk in the footsteps of **Locaha**, Mau thought, because I know that there is a dead man in there. And the ghost girl, she was in my nightmares.

I am not alone.

The girl dropped the flat-headed spear and quickly held up something else, something that also shone like metal.

'I kn-know how to use this!' she shouted very loudly. 'One step more and I will pull the trigger, I mean it!' The metal thing waved back and forth in her hands. 'Don't think I'm afraid! I'm not afraid! I could have killed you before! Just because I felt sorry for you doesn't mean you can come down here! My father will be here soon!'

She sounded excited. Mau took the view that she wanted him to have the metal thing, because by the way she was holding it with both hands and waving it about she was obviously very frightened of it.



He reached out for it, she screamed and turned her head away, something went *click*, there was a small fountain of sparks from near one end of the metal thing and, quite slowly, a little round ball rolled out of a hole in the other end and landed in the mud in front of the girl. There were ... *things* on her feet, he noticed with a sort of horrified fascination; they were like black pods and had no toes.

The girl was watching him in round-eyed terror.

Mau gently took the thing away from her, and she flattened herself against the side of the canoe as if he were the ghost.

The metal stank of something bitter and foul, but that wasn't the important thing. It had sparked. Mau knew what to do with a spark.

'Thank you for this gift of fire,' he said, and picked up his axe and ran for it before she could do anything dreadful to him.

Glossary

buttress wide base

trouser man what the islanders call the European visitors

Locaha death

6 Survival Skills

Objective

Explore the effects of writing in the first person.

Real-life adventurers can frequently find themselves in dangerous situations. Often this is conveyed through writing in the **first person**. The following extract is from an autobiography written by Heather Dawe, one of the UK's leading endurance athletes. In this extract, she describes an experience while climbing a sea cliff in North Wales with her friend Nirvana.

Extract from *Adventures in Mind* by Heather Dawe

The **karabiner** made a hollow 'plop' sound as it hit the water beneath us. A wave of realisation and vertigo suddenly washed over me. That sea is real. These cliffs are no place for me – what am I doing here? All it takes is one slip and it could be me hitting the water and quickly sinking as all of my climbing ironmongery drags me down. I felt exposed and, while she was a rope's length away from me, I knew Nirvana was uneasy too. I felt like I was losing control.

The trick with climbing in such places is to turn off the part of your brain that alerts you to the danger you should usually associate with that situation. If you climb enough, you become numbed to this alert, so accustomed to the exposure formed by height, space and location that it's normal. Right there, paused halfway up **Dream**, these places were very normal for me. Hanging around on high mountain crags and sea cliffs formed a regular part of my weekend escapes from **urbanity**. That a falling piece of climbing gear, dropped by my climbing partner, broke this state of mind for me was telling. The sound of the karabiner hitting the sea was all it took.

Glossary

first-person narrative story or experience told using the words 'I' and 'we'

karabiner a metal ring used by rockclimbers to attach themselves safely to things

Dream the name of the climb

urbanity [in this context] living in a town or city

third-person narrative story or experience told by someone outside the story, using the words 'he', 'she', 'they'

Activities

1

How does the writer convey the danger of the situation? Using a table like the one below, select specific words and phrases and comment on how they add to the sense of danger.

Words/phrases conveying danger	Effect
'hit the water'	suggests height

2a

Writing in the first person can make a significant difference to how a reader reacts to a text. Looking again at the extract, how does writing in the first person make you, the reader, feel?

2b

What difference does it make to you as you read the text that you know that this experience really happened to the writer?

2c

Imagine that the book had been a biography, therefore written in the **third person** (he/she). What difference would that make to your reaction to this extract?

SPAG

3

Write a piece for your school newspaper or magazine in which you describe, in the first person, a dangerous experience that happened to you (real or imagined). Aim to write around 200 words and try to sustain a sense of drama or danger throughout your piece. If possible, you might also like to include the second person (you).



Stretch

Why does the writer switch to writing in the second person (you) in the second paragraph? What is the effect of this on the reader?

7 At the Extremes

Objective

Compare diaries and blogs from different time periods.

Adventurers can face life at the extremes. Over a century ago, explorers raced to be the first to reach the South Pole, while today astronauts in space have opened a new frontier of exploration.

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‘Whether you are climbing a mountain or writing a book, it’s hard. But you have to keep going.’

Mick Conefrey



Activities

1

Discuss the reasons why adventurers such as explorers and astronauts keep diaries or blogs. What can we learn from these as readers?



2a

Read the extract from Captain Scott’s diary on page 27. This describes the last days of the Antarctic explorer’s failed expedition to be the first to reach the South Pole. Look at the opening paragraph. How does Scott’s style of writing suggest that this is his personal journal?

2b

Look at the second paragraph. What clues do you have that Scott isn’t just writing the diary for himself?

2c

What does Scott want readers of his diary to think about Captain Oates? Pick out details to support the points you make.



Support

Think about:

- how Scott refers to Captain Oates
- how Scott describes Captain Oates’s actions
- what Scott says about Captain Oates.

Extract from the journal of Captain Scott

Friday, March 16 or Saturday 17– Lost track of dates, but think the last correct. Tragedy all along the line. At lunch, the day before yesterday, poor Titus Oates said he couldn't go on; he proposed we should leave him in his sleeping-bag. That we could not do, and we induced him to come on, on the afternoon march. In spite of its awful nature for him he struggled on and we made a few miles. At night he was worse and we knew the end had come.

Should this be found I want these facts recorded. Oates' last thoughts were of his Mother, but immediately before he took pride in thinking that his regiment would be pleased with the bold way in which he met his death. We can testify to his bravery. He has **borne** intense suffering for weeks without complaint, and to the very last was able and willing to discuss outside subjects. He did not – would not – give up hope till the very end. He was a brave soul. This was the end. He slept through the night before last, hoping not to wake; but he woke in the morning – yesterday. It was blowing a blizzard. He said, 'I am just going outside and may be some time.' He went out into the blizzard and we have not seen him since.

Glossary

borne endured

adverbs words which describe how an action is carried out, e.g. *happily, angrily*

Now read the extract from Luca Parmitano's blog on pages 28–29. Here, the astronaut describes the moment when his spacewalk, to carry out repairs outside the International Space Station, hits a problem.

3

How does Luca Parmitano build up tension in his description of his spacewalk? Discuss:

- the way he describes what happens and his actions
- the vocabulary he uses to share his thoughts and emotions
- his use of fronted adverbials and other organizational features.

Fronted adverbials are **adverbs** and **adverbial phrases** that are placed at the front of a sentence for emphasis. Fronted adverbials such as 'At this exact moment' and 'Finally' show the sequence of time in this piece of writing.

SPAG

4

You have been asked to select one of these two texts for a school display about real-life adventurers. Write an email to the school council explaining which text you would choose and why.

More to explore 

Extract from EVA 23: exploring the frontier

At this exact moment, just as I'm thinking about how to uncoil the cable neatly (it is moving around like a thing possessed in the weightlessness), I 'feel' that something is wrong. The unexpected sensation of water at the back of my neck surprises me – and I'm in a place where I'd rather not be surprised. I move my head from side to side, confirming my first impression, and with superhuman effort I force myself to inform Houston of what I can feel, knowing that it could signal the end of this **EVA**. On the ground, Shane confirms they have received my message and he asks me to await instructions [...]

At first, we're both convinced that it must be drinking water from my flask that has leaked out through the straw, or else it's sweat. But I think the liquid is too cold to be sweat, and more importantly, I can feel it increasing [...] When I inform Chris and Shane of this, we immediately receive the order to 'terminate' the **sortie** [...] I'm instructed to go back to the airlock. Together we decide that Chris should secure all the elements that are outside before he retraces his steps to the airlock, i.e. he will first move to the front of the Station. And so we separate.

As I move back along my route towards the airlock, I become more and more certain that the water is increasing. I feel it covering the sponge on my earphones and I wonder whether I'll lose audio contact. The water has also almost completely covered the front of my visor, sticking to it and obscuring my vision [...] By now, the upper part of the helmet is full of water and I can't even be sure that the next time I breathe I will fill my lungs with air and not liquid. To make matters worse, I realise that I can't even understand which direction I should head in to get back to the airlock [...]

A photograph of an astronaut in a white spacesuit floating in space next to a large satellite with multiple solar panels. The Earth's blue and white surface is visible in the background.

I try to contact Chris and Shane. I listen as they talk to each other, but their voices are very faint now. I can hardly hear them and they can't hear me. I'm alone. I frantically think of a plan [...] It's not much, but it's the best idea I have: to follow the cable to the airlock [...]

Finally, with a huge sense of relief, I peer through the curtain of water before my eyes and make out the thermal cover of the airlock: just a little further and I'll be safe [...] Moving with my eyes closed, I manage to get inside and position myself to wait for Chris' return. I sense movement behind me; Chris enters the airlock and judging from the vibrations, I know that he's closing the hatch [...]

Now that we are repressurizing, I know that if the water does overwhelm me I can always open the helmet. I'll probably lose consciousness, but in any case that would be better than drowning inside the helmet.

Glossary

EVA extra-vehicular activity, e.g. a spacewalk

sortie mission

Extra Time

1. What do both extracts suggest about team spirit and how is this expressed?
2. Write your own blog or diary entry about an adventure you have had or would like to have.

8 Worth the Risk?

Objective

Discuss whether dangerous pursuits have any place in the modern world.

Nowadays, you don't need to be an adventurer to take part in dangerous pursuits. Adventure holidays and extreme sports give ordinary people the chance to find the thrills that explorers and other intrepid adventurers faced in the past. But are these activities worth the risk?



Activities

1 Read Simon Jenkins' opinion column on page 31. Summarize what his views are on why people travel overseas to take part in extreme sports and dangerous activities.

2 What examples does Simon Jenkins give to support his point of view? Do you find these persuasive?

3 Your school has asked the student council to discuss a proposal to include adventure sports and activities such as climbing, kayaking and BMX biking in the P.E. curriculum. Follow the steps on the right to discuss this proposal and agree on a decision.

Preparation: Note down your own thoughts and ideas on this proposal. Identify the most relevant points and place these in order of importance. Add explanations and examples to the ideas you think you will use in the discussion.

Discussion: Share your ideas. Listen to others and build on their ideas to move the discussion forward. Ask **open questions** to encourage others to explain or expand their contributions.

Decision: Summarize the points of view for and against the proposal. Vote to reach a decision on the proposal. Prepare a brief explanation of your decision and the reasons for it.



FROM GREENLAND TO MOUNT EVEREST, THIS IS THE SEASON OF RECKLESS JAUNTS

A young Briton dies trying to cross Greenland in a blizzard. Another goes missing while trying to sail the Pacific. Three climbers narrowly escape death in a mob fight on Mount Everest. Three sailors plan to pedalo across the Atlantic. That is all inside a week...

This is the season when crazy tourism **goes viral**, when "gappers" dream up dangerous adventures and when no holiday is complete without some display of **machismo**. The latest to boom are base jumping, hang-gliding, cave-diving and cycling across deserts.

We once thought this was merely a British craving to escape the Health and Safety Executive. If boys can no longer dive into a local swimming pool, they will dive off a Greek cliff. If they are not allowed to ride a horse without a crash helmet and sack of insurance certificates, they will ride a bull in Pamplona. Take adventure out of Britain and you take Britain out of adventure...

Back in time, taking risk was life and death. Miners, sailors, builders, quarrymen suffered appalling injuries to support their families. To early explorers danger was the price of discovery. Columbus would not have set sail in a pedalo. Edmund Hillary would not have climbed Everest without oxygen. Risking death as a pastime would have seemed irrational, except for sports with origins in military prowess, such as hunting, boxing and fencing.

The mad and mostly illegal sport of base jumping – from a cliff with a parachute – now sees some 15 deaths a year. One jump in 60 is said to end in a fatality and a successful jump is "one you survive". A high risk of death or injury attends pursuits such as motorbiking, big-wave surfing, altitude climbing and, a new craze, **street lugging**. People even go sailing off the Somalian coast to defy the pirates.

All these people are seeking thrills which, by definition, they cannot find at home. Home nowadays is beyond tame. School pupils cannot swim in Snowdonia lakes without trained lifesavers on hand. Children cannot go kayaking without attendant motor boats. You need a safety course to go on a hill walk.

Glossary

open question a question which cannot be simply answered by 'yes' or 'no'

goes viral spreads rapidly

machismo an exaggerated sense of manliness

street lugging riding a sledge down a steep road



9 Assessment: Analysing Literary Non-fiction Extracts

Your Head Teacher is delivering an assembly to a local Primary school about the adventure of moving to Secondary school. She wants to begin her assembly with a reading about explorers who have been brave enough to break new ground. She has asked Year 7 students to choose which of the following two extracts she should read and to explain why this extract will appeal to Year 6 students.

The first is an extract from *The Lost City of Z* by David Grann, which describes the British explorer Colonel Percy Harrison Fawcett's expedition party coming under attack in the Amazon jungle. The second extract is written by the explorer Kira Salak and describes her encounter with a witch doctor in Papua New Guinea.

Having read both extracts, choose one to analyse. Use the skills you have developed throughout this unit to write a letter to your Head Teacher explaining why your chosen extract will hold the attention of the Year 6 audience. In your letter you should refer to evidence from the extract and comment on:

- the situation the explorer finds themselves in and how they react
- what the extract suggests about the dangers involved in exploration
- the devices which the writer uses to make the passage exciting, such as sentence structure, vocabulary, imagery and dialogue.

Planning your letter...

Read both extracts and select the one you want to analyse. Think about the bullet points on the left as you re-read the extract. Make notes of any details that you think it might be helpful to refer to when you write your letter to the Head Teacher.

Writing your letter...

Remember that in your letter, you will need to:

- Use **Standard English**.
- Refer to evidence and quotations from the text.
- Start with an introductory paragraph.
- Group your analysis of the extract into separate paragraphs.
- Finish with a clear conclusion.

Note that, for the purposes of this assessment, you will be marked on your reading and analysis skills, rather than on your writing skills.

Extract from *The Lost City of Z* by David Grann

A member of Fawcett's team dived into the water, shouting, "Retire! Retire!" But Fawcett insisted on pulling the boats to the opposite bank, as arrows continued to cascade from the sky. "One of these came within a foot of my head, and I actually saw the face of the savage who fired it," Costin later recalled. Fawcett ordered his men to drop their rifles, but the barrage of arrows persisted. And so Fawcett instructed one of the men, as further demonstration of their peaceful intentions, to pull out his accordion and play it. The rest of the party, commanded to stand and face their deaths without protest, sang along as Costin, first in a trembling voice, then more fervently, called out the words to "The Soldiers of the Queen": "In the fight for England's glory, lads / Of its world wide glory let us sing."

Fawcett then did something that shocked Costin so much that he would recall it vividly even as an old man: the major untied the handkerchief around his neck and, waving it above his head, waded into the river, heading directly into the **fusillade** of arrows. Over the years, Fawcett had picked up scraps of Indian dialects, scribbling the words in his logbooks and studying them at night, and he called out the few fragments of vocabulary he knew, repeating friend, friend, friend, not sure if the word that he was shouting was even right, as the water from the river rose to his armpits. Then the arrows ceased. For a moment, no one moved as Fawcett stood in the river, hands above head, like a **penitent** being baptized. According to Costin, an Indian appeared from behind a tree and came down to the edge of the river. Paddling out towards Fawcett in a raft, he took the handkerchief from Fawcett's hand. "The Major made signs for him to be taken across," Costin later recounted in a letter to his daughter, and the Indian "poled back to his side with Fawcett kneeling on his flimsy craft."

"On climbing the opposite bank," Fawcett said, "I had the unpleasant anticipation of receiving a shot in the face or an arrow in the stomach."

The Indians led him away. "[Fawcett] disappeared into the forest, and we were left wondering!" Costin said. The party feared that its leader had been slaughtered until, nearly an hour later, he emerged from the jungle with an Indian cheerfully wearing his Stetson.

Glossary

Standard English the variety of English that is regarded as 'correct' and is used in more formal situations. It is not specific to any geographical area and can be spoken or written.

fusillade a series of shots in quick succession

penitent someone repenting for their sins

More to
explore

Extract from *Four Corners: A Journey into the Heart of Papua New Guinea* by Kira Salak

It's the late afternoon when we leave the canoe behind for a hike to the witch doctor's village. We follow a faint, muddy path through **primeval** jungle, trees towering at least a hundred feet above us, vines creeping from limb to limb, hugging trunks and hanging from boughs like gigantic tentacles.

The path opens up. We see a small village on the edge of a large stream. Mountains of rain forest rise to the south, clouds **languishing** about them, the departing sun already warming the sky and jungle with an orange glow. Everything looks softened, as if a god were resting a gentle hand upon the earth, quieting it, preparing it for rest. Joseph calls out. Some kids playing in a stream look at us, freeze, then run off in terror.

"They never see white people," Joseph explains.

A man in a dingy, unbuttoned white shirt, wearing a breechcloth and **pandanus** leaves around his waist, comes out to greet us. **Cassowary** claws erupt from the tops of each of his nostrils, and large hoop earrings made from bird **quills** graze his shoulders. A band of bright red and yellow beads encircles his head.

"This is the Chief," Joseph says. "The witch doctor."

The Chief looks at us sternly before he disappears into the jungle. Confused, we soon hear a low-pitched, ominous whooping coming from nearby. Suddenly a man bursts forth with spear held aloft. Bright yellow paint covers his body. Pandanus leaves are tied about his arms and legs. He charges toward us with a sharp holler, and I find myself running for my life. I retreat toward the village but am quickly cut off, the Chief's spear only inches from my face.



He smiles. I try to smile back. Thirty years ago, I may have actually been speared. Now he lowers the spear and shows it to me. He insists I run my fingers down the length of its shaft, touch the sharp bamboo point. Jens comes over, and thus begins a heated discussion about whether the spear is for sale and how much it costs. Rob wants a spear, too, and so the Chief's friend runs off to his hut to get some more. It's the Home Shopping Network, **PNG-style**, spears, bows and arrows laid out for our **kina**. Jens pulls off his T-shirt and exchanges it for several arrows.

I wander off along the stream, watching the mountains growing increasingly pink in the declining light. Children hide behind the posts of the stilt huts, watching me silently. An old woman wearing only a grass skirt comes toward me and hands me a few of the mourning necklaces she's made. She pats my hand, says something to me, and smiles a toothless grin. Thinking she's trying to sell them to me, I reach for some kina to pay her, but she shakes her head and speaks softly to me in her **tok ples** language. She pats my hand again and I watch her shuffle off, back bent, bare feet following the ground's well-worn path. I am beginning to understand.

Glossary

primeval ancient

languishing growing weak

pandanus a tropical tree

cassowary a large flightless bird from Papua New Guinea

quills bird feathers

PNG-style Papua New Guinea style

kina money used in Papua New Guinea

tok ples language used by the tribes in Papua New Guinea

